Research Statement

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My research lies at the intersection of macroeconomics and labor economics, with a focus on job search, worker mobility, sorting, and compensation. I am interested in how labor market frictions and institutional features—both informational and contractual—shape where workers sort across employers and how they are paid, and what the resulting implications are for efficiency and inequality. My current work pursues these questions through two complementary projects: a structural study of how promotions and unemployment shape sorting under asymmetric information, and a reduced-form empirical investigation of how retirement plan design affects worker mobility and wages.

Job Market Paper: Promotions, Unemployment, and Labor Market Sorting Under Asymmetric Information

My job market paper studies how promotions and unemployment jointly determine labor market sorting and wages. Using the NLSY79, I document that previously promoted workers face disproportionately large wage losses upon re-employment—averaging 15% below pre-separation wages versus 1% for non-promoted workers—and that these losses grow significantly with unemployment duration, at a rate of 0.55 percentage points per month compared to 0.14 for their non-promoted counterparts. I also find that a substantial share of promotions are awarded to workers who are plausibly low-ability, suggesting that the promotion signal itself is noisy and that firms face a non-trivial assignment problem both internally and when hiring from outside. I interpret these facts through a structural model in which firms learn about worker ability from employment history. Promotions serve as positive signals of ability, but prolonged unemployment acts as a noisy counteracting signal, causing many formerly promoted workers to be re-employed in lower-level positions—a form of downward mobility driven entirely by information frictions rather than changes in productivity. The model also delivers policy implications for unemployment insurance design: benefit profiles tied to past wages worsen sorting and reduce aggregate output by distorting the informativeness of unemployment duration as an ability signal, while policies targeted toward low-ability workers improve sorting.

Work in Progress: Retirement Plan Design, Worker Mobility, and Wages

Joint with Martin Gervais.

This project examines how employer-sponsored retirement plan design affects worker mobility and wages. We construct a novel dataset by scraping retirement plan information for all U.S. firms with more than 1,000 employees, capturing detailed variation in vesting schedule structures and employer contribution generosity. To our knowledge, no existing dataset provides this level of coverage of plan-level design features across the near-universe of large U.S. employers. Linking this to employer–employee matched administrative data, we pursue a reduced-form strategy that exploits cross-firm variation in plan design to identify how vesting schedules and benefit generosity affect turnover and wages. Vesting provisions create explicit financial penalties for early separation that may suppress voluntary job mobility, particularly around vesting cliffs, while more generous retirement contributions may be partially offset by lower wages—a form of compensating differential operating through the non-wage margin. By documenting these relationships, the paper contributes to our understanding of how non-wage compensation shapes equilibrium labor market outcomes.

Future Research

Because detailed retirement plan data of this kind is essentially absent from the existing literature, the dataset assembled above opens many doors for original and valuable research. Among the most promising directions are questions about the frictions and inefficiencies that current plan designs introduce into the labor market. For instance, vesting schedules may distort workers' optimal separation decisions, generating inefficient lock-in that a structural model could quantify and evaluate against alternative plan designs. Separately, contribution formulas tied to salary and lengthy vesting requirements raise questions about the distributional consequences of plan design, as these features may disproportionately benefit higher earners and compound existing wage inequality through the retirement savings channel. Beyond these two directions, the data is rich enough to speak to questions about firm-level sorting, the role of benefits in job search, and the interaction between retirement plan generosity and wage bargaining. These represent just a subset of the questions this dataset is well-positioned to address.